

“The damage has been done”: AI Diplomacy and the Impact of Geopolitical Tensions on AI Tool Acceptance in Denmark in Q1 2026

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Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) tools are increasingly embedded in software development workflows. Since the Greenland Crisis of early 2026, there has been a renewed push for evaluation of European reliance on American tech. The concern over American GenAI tools is particularly relevant in Denmark who was in the direct line of fire during the geopolitical tension escalation. Through questionnaires (N=13) and interviews (N=12) with software developers, we examine how developers reflect on the GenAI tools they are using, how geopolitical tensions inform GenAI tool usage, and who is responsible for selecting GenAI tools. Our findings show that American GenAI acceptance has wavered with multiple developers actively seeking alternatives to American tech while others raised concerns about a lack of European alternatives as a main barrier for change. Our study provides an important snapshot in time, of how political tension affects collaborative technologies on the ground while reinforcing AI sovereignty as a future avenue of research.

CCS Concepts: • **Social and professional topics** → **Geographic characteristics**; **Government technology policy**; **Computing and business**; • **Information systems** → *Information retrieval*; • **Security and privacy** → *Human and societal aspects of security and privacy*; • **Computing methodologies** → Artificial intelligence.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: AI sovereignty, geopolitical tensions in technology, EU-centric technology

ACM Reference Format:

Eszter Vigh and Louise Barkhuus. 2026. “The damage has been done”: AI Diplomacy and the Impact of Geopolitical Tensions on AI Tool Acceptance in Denmark in Q1 2026. In *Companion of the Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW Companion '26)*, October 10–14, 2026, Salt Lake City, UT, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 8 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3785651.3831498>

1 Introduction

The Greenland Crisis that started January 20, 2025, reached an escalation period December 22, 2025 through January 21, 2026 where the United States government threatened to annex Greenland, an autonomous territory of EU member state Denmark [12]. During the escalation period and immediately following that period we engaged software developers utilizing Gen AI tools in Denmark, in a study on AI tool implementation in software development collaborative workflows. The public release of OpenAI’s ChatGPT in November 2022 marked a turning point in this shift and quickly brought generative AI to unprecedented user bases [19]. Since then, the work-AI ecosystem has expanded to include key players such as GitHub Copilot, Google’s Gemini, and Anthropic’s Claude, but notably the tools being adopted are owned by American corporations, with European counterparts such as Mistral lagging behind in adoption. These tools promise productivity gains, faster problem solving, and relevant support for both novice and experienced workers particularly

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CSCW Companion '26, Salt Lake City, UT, USA

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-2378-0/2026/10

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3785651.3831498>

software developers [35]. At the same time, the recent geopolitical tensions have led to discussions around AI Sovereignty and what developers quietly resign to when they use tools developed by territorial adversaries. Public media contain endless discussions on ethics of AI usage, when it should be used, how it should be used, who should have access, and for what tasks AI should be used for. In 2025, Denmark set aside 12 million USD to help improve digital sovereignty and make the country less reliant on American tech giants like Microsoft [11]. Notably Aarhus Municipality, the second-largest city, has begun developing its own AI assistant [28] with other cities planning to do so as well.

In this paper we explore the following research question: **How did the Greenland Crisis affect software developers' attitudes toward, and selection of, AI tools developed by geopolitical adversaries?** We addressed this question by administering a questionnaire and conducting interviews with thirteen software developers based in Denmark. The results were analyzed using thematic analysis [7, 8].

2 Related Work

Previous work has shown that AI use is contingent and selective rather than habitual, where developers primarily rely on AI for low-complexity, low-accountability tasks, while deliberately limiting use in security-critical or system-defining work [34]. Existing generative software development intelligent agents are divided into four categories according to their design philosophy [38]: 1) Passive Agent (e.g., ChatGPT [10], Copilot Chat [15], Code Interpreter [24]), 2) Auto-Thinking Agent (e.g., AutoGPT [14]), 3) Multi-Agent Collaboration Agent (e.g., MetaGPT [20], ChatDev [29]), and 4) Questioning Agent (e.g., GPT-Engineer [36], GPT-Pilot [39]). Regardless of concerns around the integration of this new form of automation, generative AI continues to be integrated into work practices to support knowledge workers' tasks with the goal of improving the quality and delivery time of their work [17].

2.1 AI Tool Sovereignty

EU Digital Sovereignty has been elevated to a priority for the EU Cyber Agenda to build a free, safe, and resilient cyberspace [9]. However, EU AI policy has been characterized as prioritizing jurisdictional independence over citizen sovereignty, embracing a global AI race logic that neglects its impact on people beyond the EU [27]. This is positioning that other scholars argue feeds into rising geo-economic tensions [27]. AI's relationship to power and sovereignty is not singular: AI payoffs relate to instrumental, structural, and discursive power in distinct ways [30]. Following Lukes' three faces of power [25], corporations exercise discursive power by shaping the preferences, identities, and reputations that govern corporate-society relations [30]. Given common critiques of AI as agreeable [6] and homogenizing code in ways meant to be broadly 'understandable' [33], the discursive power held by predominantly U.S.-based AI tools is notable: these tools are products of specific cultural histories, and their adoption raises questions about whose interpretations of training data circulate globally [22]. Prior work frames this as a sovereignty threat, since non-state actors can exercise power simply by controlling access to AI tools shaped by their own corporate values [31], prompting a broader re-evaluation of sovereignty itself in light of AI adoption at scale [32]. Our findings extend this discussion to the level of everyday developer practice: where prior work theorizes sovereignty as a property of states and corporations, our participants' deferral to management and selective avoidance of American tools show sovereignty being negotiated or quietly relinquished one tool choice at a time.

2.2 Greenland Crisis

Greenland is an autonomous territory of the Kingdom of Denmark [23], one of five Arctic littoral states alongside the US, Russia, Norway, and Canada [5]. Greenland has increasingly been framed as a site of US–China strategic competition and a potential source of uranium [18], and the second Trump administration shifted its posture toward the territory amid broader Arctic tensions [13]. US control over Greenland would extend American strategic reach across Arctic North America and access to its resources [12, 37]. This shift became explicit in a January 18, 2026 message from President Trump to Norway's Prime Minister, which characterized Danish sovereignty over Greenland as historically contingent and called for "Complete and Total Control of Greenland" [16] despite that sovereignty being well-established under international law and repeatedly acknowledged in writing by the US itself, including in 1917, 1941, 1951, and 2004 [1, 2, 4]. The Danish public reacted sharply, boycotting US-branded products [21, 26]. It is this acute, non-repeatable rupture and the boycott sentiment it produced that forms the backdrop against which our participants' attitudes toward American GenAI tools should be read.

3 Methods

Our empirical material consists of a questionnaire completed by thirteen participants and follow-up interviews conducted with twelve of them; findings draw on both sources, as one participant contributed exclusively through the questionnaire. All participants work professionally in software development. Participants were recruited through professional networks affiliated with the research project, using a purposive sampling strategy aimed at recruiting developers with relevant experience of generative AI tools in professional contexts. Data collection took place in January–February 2026, concurrent with the Greenland Crisis escalation. Interviews were semi-structured, lasting approximately one hour, and conducted in English through Microsoft Teams. All interviews were transcribed verbatim and anonymized prior to analysis. The thematic analysis followed the six phases outlined by Braun and Clarke [7, 8]. Transcripts were reviewed and coded by both authors throughout. Participants provided informed consent prior to each interview and were reminded at its conclusion that they could request exclusion of their data prior to anonymization.

4 Participants

Access to participants was facilitated through a combination of opportunity-based and convenience-oriented recruitment channels. Inclusion criteria required participants to (1) work professionally with software development and (2) use GenAI tools in their workflow. The participants each gave informed consent in line with university ethics guidance on human participant consent. The full demographic table of participants can be found in Table 1.

5 Findings

Participants described the tensions between using AI tools to stay competitive in their profession with pressure from personal values and company expectations. All of the participants expressed worries about code ending up outside their own company, specifically mentioning "abroad" (P1) and others specifically the US. P2 for example answered the question of **"How has the current geopolitical climate informed the tools you utilize?"**: *"Yeah, that worries me. [...] I'm worried about sharing my own data with wrong parties and [that] it can be misused and [...] I mean, of course the main tools are from the US and things are going on in the world and not at least in the US."* While this seemed to be a very common basic viewpoint, going into more details our findings supported three themes surrounding American AI tools for software development.

Table 1. Participant demographics and AI tool usage

P#	Age	Job Title	Time at Company	AI Tools Utilized	Time Using AI	AI Freq.
P1	52	Senior Solution Architect	11 years	Microsoft Copilot, GitHub Copilot, Claude, Codex	1–2 years	Daily
P2	60	Senior Program Manager	18 years	Microsoft Copilot, ChatGPT, Gemini	1–2 years	Daily
P3	45	UX Strategist	1.5 years	Microsoft Copilot, Power Automate, Internal AI	Past 3 months	Daily
P4	37	Senior UX Specialist	3 years	Figma, Microsoft Copilot, Adobe Firefly, ChatGPT, Gemini	1–2 years	Rarely
P5	36	Software Developer	2 years	GitHub Copilot, Claude	2+ years	Daily
P6	35	Senior Software Developer	4 years	GitHub Copilot	3–12 months	Daily
P7	34	Senior Software Developer	8 years	GitHub Copilot, Claude	3–12 months	Weekly
P8	53	Tool Architect	5 months	Grok, Claude, Gemini, ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, MS Copilot, Codex	2+ years	Daily
P9	48	Solution Architect	3 years	GitHub Copilot, ChatGPT, Bing	1–2 years	Daily
P10	37	Senior UX Consultant	1 year	GitHub Copilot, ChatGPT, Codex	1–2 years	Rarely
P11	25	Software Developer	4 years	ChatGPT, OpenCode, GitHub Copilot, Claude, Gemini	2+ years	Daily
P12	26	Software Developer	3 months	GitHub Copilot	2+ years	Daily
P13	31	Frontend Developer	4 months	GitHub Copilot	3–12 months	Daily

5.1 Theme 1: Passively Leaving the Decisions to Management

Five participants were concerned but had not changed practices, because their managers and leadership in the company had not told them explicitly that they were not allowed to use AI tools. They reiterated that because they use the internal tool (CoPilot), it was okay and ultimately, *“I’m not concerned since if my company isn’t concerned.”* (P3).

Three of the developers had even reached out to the managerial level to inquire what kind of guidelines they should follow when using US based AI tools: *“so I guess he [manager] is not that concerned about it”*, P5 continued. Others, like P9 explained how it was more about not being in a position of power, *“So for work, I’m not in a position where I can decide on things [...] So I’ve been using AI tools and I’m not really a strong advocate.”* This same lack of AI tool deciding power and passive acceptance of management was also illustrated by P11 when speaking to data processing:

OK, yeah, so for work I am completely under the data. I can only use the tools that we use here and I don’t have much say in that. But I know that we have, we are looking into EU alternatives for many different things. [...] We have models in production that does predictions for many different things. I don’t think I can say, but we’re looking into changing these models to not be used under Azure, but to go through the Danish supercomputer [...] but it’s not really my say in that I think.

The passive acceptance of the company’s explanation of things was not because a lack of awareness of the risk that these AI tools can expose customer data to. As P6 explained:

When asking about this, we have been told that the data retention policy in the subscription we have, means that we can use it with customers without fearing that the, without feeling that their data are leaked or that [...] any code that is read or generated is used for training, but in the end it comes down to, do you trust those policies to be actually in accordance with the actual truth? And for now we must assume that they are, but I’m also open to the possibility that [...] in a few years we discovered that was not the case. I hope not, but stranger things have happened.

It is this passivity that makes for tension between previous studies that found how developers feel responsible for the code they produce using the tools [34]. That responsibility stops when choosing

the tools they develop said code with. We also observed some quiet questioning of who should have the authority to decide on the tools being used, but the questioning stopped short of action, as articulated by P13:

Who should set the guidelines? me? the company? the politicians? and how can a company take a responsible choice regarding the use of AI when they compete with companies who use it without thought?

5.2 Theme 2: Personally Purging American Tech Before Something Goes Wrong

The movement around actually distancing from American Tech seems to originate from personal discussions outside of the work context. A P5 put it, *"And here in my family, we're talking about, you know, can we use other tools than, you know, Chrome for browsing? There's a Norwegian one and so on."* For developers such as P12, this focus on removing American tech goes a ways deeper,

Actually, I'm trying to disconnect from American tech generally in my private life. Well, I've generally been anti-personal surveillance and like stuff like that for a bit. And then since the Americans keep electing dumb presidents and keep threatening like European sovereignty and stuff like that. I've removed Google from my life and tried to remove Microsoft, but that's difficult, especially in work related scenarios since it's so deeply ingrained. Yes, I've used the Mistral for a bit, but it's not very good, at least from my experience so far.

The main issue is how the participant's workplace is so reliant on infrastructure provided by, in their case, US tech giant Microsoft. The timing of these moves is also not necessarily tied to the Greenland Crisis, but rather events prior, such as the case with P10:

Yes, I have been using Mistral for a year ago [sic]. [...] After Trump was reelected, I ditched ChatGPT and I used, I paid for Mistral for a little over half a year, but it was just, [...] there was a strong desire for me to not use an American service, use something European. But [...] I ended up switching back because it was too bad. But I follow along what the Mistral is doing and at some point I'm thinking I'm gonna switch back because I prefer to use a European service for sure.

Two participants confirmed that a shift had already started, P3 for example explained: *"But I do see things happening towards, you know being more at least European minded and focused and I'm sure the damage has been done in a sense where Europe figures out that it has to find its own feet in all of this."* It was not a question of if Europe will find its feet in this setting, it was viewed as a *must* by now; yet participants such as P6 stopped short of wanting tools to be Danish:

I mean, it would be lovely if it was in Denmark, but it's probably not realistic. Yeah. Yeah, I mean in some senses we do have a lot of advantages here being very digitized, very digitally minded in in Denmark, a very digital public sector. I had a lot of IT literacy, so I think there's something to be said for it, but I don't think it's realistic that [the AI tools are] going to be [based] in Denmark.

5.3 Theme 3: Reluctance to Rely on Worse European Tech

A major barrier to adopting competing European AI Tools such as Mistral was the legal frameworks the tools have to operate under that make them inferior to those developed in the US. P8 explained:

There are reasons why this creative process is happening much faster in the United States. This is a whole topic in and of itself, because they're allowed to just... We have lots of rules in EU and I know that some are trying to change that because they know

we will be inferior, we will lose. [...] I'm less critic[al] maybe, because, [...] the difference is just hilariously big.

The main concern around not using the tools developed in Europe was that as far as **software development** the European tools were not meeting the expectations of developers. P7 outlined:

And right now I think it's a very depressing answer for why I'm not using something else. There's not really any competent alternatives, I think. I know that there is a company in France, Mistral, I think AI, but from what I've heard and at least in our field of work, I don't think they are really up to par with the alternatives yet. But if there was, if there was a tool in Europe, in the EU that was like performing at the same level, I would absolutely prefer it and push to get that into our working tools because there are not really any good reasons to use anyone else right now, neither American nor the Chinese alternatives.

Notably P7 was the only participant to mention Chinese technology in any capacity over the course of the study.

6 Limitations and Future Work

The sample size of the study is relatively small and not exhaustive or representative of all permutations of AI tool usage in Denmark. None of the participants referenced utilizing non-American AI tools for work purposes. There is a difference between experimenting with AI tools for personal use and implementing the tools into client workflows. Future work should engage with less technical or tangentially technical staff and their AI tool usage as well as look into continued efforts of Denmark and other countries experimenting with and adopting non-American AI tools.

7 Conclusion

There is a delicate balance between trying to maintain independence from foreign technology and remaining competitive from a capitalist perspective. Employees are not necessarily in the position to make a stand, and individuals choosing not to use American technology do not ultimately impact the AI companies who have sold licenses to the companies the individual developers are employed at. The licenses may be bought, but the sovereignty landscape keeps changing. Concerns are growing over different AI tools being GDPR compliant, notably Microsoft Copilot, which introduced flex routing in April 2026, meaning that EU-hosted data do not necessarily mean EU-processed data, when entered into Copilot. This flex routing is a default feature meaning that many EU based businesses may no longer be GDPR compliant following this change [3]. At the tail of the Greenland Crisis, there were clearly a desire for the European alternatives to be used, directly attributed to the political situation, but they were not useful for the workflows the developers need them for. That coupled with the attitude that the decisions need to be made by company leaders removes software developers from a position of accountability, an interesting contrast to previous work that found they feel accountable for the code they produced with GenAI [34]. That accountability seemingly ends when it comes to deciding what tools get used to begin with.

Acknowledgments

This work was funded by Digital Research Centre Denmark under the project "Understanding and Supporting Secure AI Tools in Software Development Teams".

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